STATE SCAN

MAHARASHTRA: METER DOWN OVER MARATHI *PG 18*

WESTERN GHATS: THE OTHER SIDE IS NOT GREENER *PG 22*



FLOATING VOTE A fisherman on the Gomti in Lucknow

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▶ UTTAR PRADESH

FISHING FOR THE BOATMEN

All parties are angling for a bigger slice of the crucial Nishad vote. The riverine caste bloc ups its price by insisting on SC listing

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

THE SARAYU FLOWS PAST AYODHYA, PLACING IT SQUARELY WITHIN THE rich riverine network of Uttar Pradesh. Communities tied to that Gangetic life-world have always cohabited with its more hallowed denizens. Yet, a recent fish feast in town has triggered a row, and how the turbulence shapes up has acquired a special significance. At a Nishad community event—attended by UP Congress chief Ajay Rai—there was fish on the menu. This being the town of the temple, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) promptly accused the Congress of hurting religious sentiments. The Congress, in turn, called it a question of food traditions and the cultural identity of riverine communities.

The undercurrents? Well, as UP prepares for the 2027 assembly election, the Nishad vote is becoming a contest all its own. The BJP has had an alliance with the Nishad Party (NP) for seven years; the Samajwadi Party (SP) and Congress are looking to pry that open. What makes it riveting is an unresolved issue related to reservation. All the attention has given the NP a lever